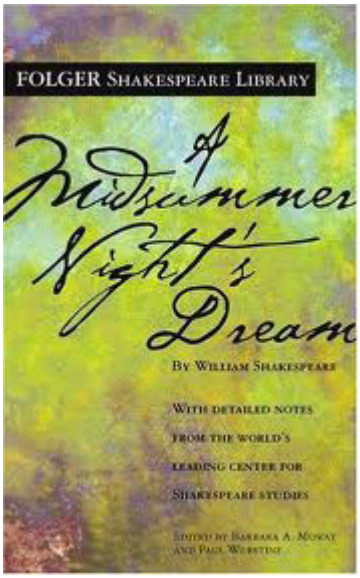
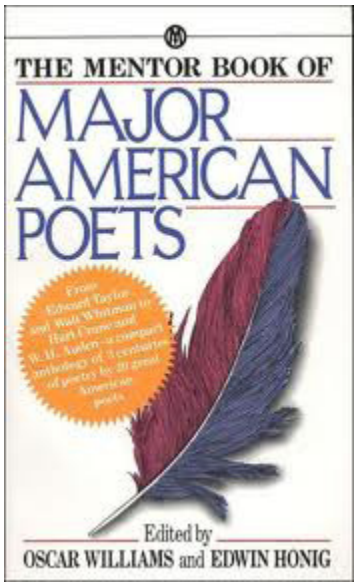
UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE

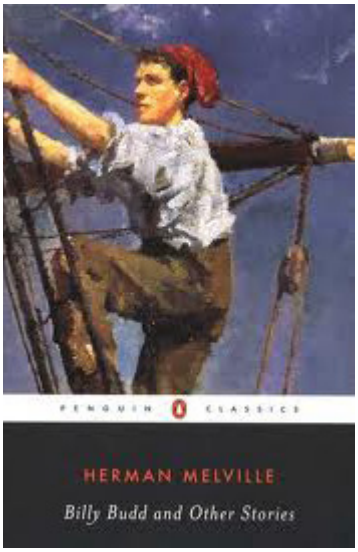
Making a World of Difference

# Literary Criticism

## District 2 • 2012




DO NOT TURN THIS PAGE UNTIL
YOU ARE INSTRUCTED TO DO SO!

# University Interscholastic League
# Literary Criticism Contest • District 2 • 2012

**Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History** **30 items (1 point each)**

1. The financial support that until well into the nineteenth century provided authors and other artists who could not make a living on their writing or art alone the wherewithal to continue to create is called
   A) acknowledgements.
   B) collaboration.
   C) decadence.
   D) inscription.
   E) patronage.

2. The figure of speech that makes a brief reference to a historical, literary, or cultural figure, event, or object is
   A) allusion.
   B) apostrophe.
   C) epiphany.
   D) tableau.
   E) vignette.

3. In early nineteenth-century America, the group of poets, including John Greenleaf Whittier, William Cullen Bryant, Henry Wadsworth Longfellow, and James Russell Lowell, devoted to providing intellectual and moral education is known as the
   A) Fireside Poets.
   B) Fugitives.
   C) Hartford Wits.
   D) Lost Generation.
   E) Transcendental Club.

4. The author of *Song of Solomon* and 1988 recipient of the Pulitzer Prize for Fiction for her novel *Beloved* is
   A) Geraldine Brooks.
   B) Harper Lee.
   C) Toni Morrison.
   D) Marilynne Robinson.
   E) Anne Tyler.

5. The seventeenth-century soldiers and courtiers who, as followers of Charles I, composed lighthearted poems are known as the
   A) Bluestockings.
   B) Cavalier Lyricists.
   C) Dadaists.
   D) *Jongleurs*.
   E) Roundheads.

6. The study of allegorical symbols, especially in the Bible, in which much of the Hebrew Bible is read as a type of the revelation to come in the New Testament is
   A) calligraphy.
   B) exegesis.
   C) intertextuality.
   D) transliteration.
   E) typology.

7. The French author of the satirical critique of human nature entitled *Penguin Island* who was awarded the 1921 Nobel Prize for Literature is
   A) Henri Bergson.
   B) Anatole France.
   C) Frédéric Mistral.
   D) Romain Rolland.
   E) René F. A. Sully-Prudhomme.

8. The turn in thought—from question to answer, problem to solution—that occurs at the beginning of the sestet in the Italian sonnet or in the Shakespearean sonnet between the twelfth and thirteenth lines is the
   A) anastrophe.
   B) hyperbaton.
   C) inversion.
   D) transposition.
   E) volta.

9. The recipient of the 2005 Pulitzer Prize for Poetry for his *Delight and Shadows* is
   A) Stephen Dunn.
   B) Galway Kinnell.
   C) Yusef Komunyakaa.
   D) Ted Kooser.
   E) Charles Wright.

10. **Not** among the types of versification characterized by artificial concerns of both rhythm and rhyme is known as
    A) blank verse.
    B) clerihew.
    C) doggerel.
    D) free verse.
    E) *terza rima*.

11. The prolific twentieth-century British author of *A Severed Head*, *The Nice and the Good*, *The Black Prince*, *Nuns and Soldiers*, and *The Good Apprentice* is

A) Nadine Gordimer.
B) Doris Lessing.
C) Iris Murdock.
D) Muriel Spark.
E) Virginia Woolf.

12. The often intentional harsh and inharmonious sounds creating a marked breaking of the music of poetry is called

A) ambivalence.
B) assonance.
C) consonance.
D) dissonance.
E) resonance.

13. The author of *The Pickwick Papers*, *Oliver Twist*, *Nicholas Nickleby*, *David Copperfield*, and *Little Dorrit* is the nineteenth-century British novelist

A) Arnold Bennett.
B) Charles Dickens.
C) George Eliot.
D) Thomas Hardy.
E) William Makepeace Thackeray.

14. The early mid-nineteenth-century reform movement in England that undertook to prove the divine origin of the Anglican Church in an effort to stop the state threat to the church's revenues and authority is

A) the Great Awakening.
B) Minimalism.
C) the Oxford Movement.
D) Surrealism.
E) Vorticism.

15. In its figurative sense, the special usage of words, often without the conscious knowledge of the author or reader, in which there is a change in the word's or words' basic meanings is

A) denotation.
B) diction.
C) digression.
D) imagery.
E) plain style.

16. **Not** among the works of the nineteenth-century American novelist, short-story writer, essayist, and poet Herman Melville is

A) *Billy Budd, Sailor, An Inside Narrative*.
B) *Mardi: And a Voyage Thither*.
C) *McTeague: A Story of San Francisco*.
D) *Moby-Dick; or, The Whale*.
E) *Typee: A Peep at Polynesian Life*.

17. The common notion that all aspects of human life may be represented as a theater or theatrical performance is understood in the phrase

A) stream of consciousness.
B) suspension of disbelief.
C) Theater of Cruelty.
D) Theater of the Absurd.
E) theatrum mundi.

18. A short narrative characterized by an element of truth and detailing particulars of an interesting episode or event is a(n)

A) anecdote.
B) chronicle.
C) collage.
D) framework-story.
E) *Märchen*.

19. The transitional age in British literary history, the interval between 1750 and 1798, during which Neoclassicism yielded towards Romanticism, is known as the

A) Age of Johnson.
B) Age of the Romantic Movement.
C) Augustan Age.
D) Edwardian Age.
E) Restoration Age.

20. The process of reasoning that moves from general principles to individual cases and which is central to the investigatory process undertaken by Sir Colin Doyle's Sherlock Holmes is

A) deduction.
B) elaboration.
C) flashforward.
D) induction.
E) logocentrism.

21. The form of light verse that follows a definite pattern: five anapestic lines of which the first, second, and fifth, consisting of three feet, rhyme; and the third and fourth lines, consisting of two feet, rhyme, is the

A) dizain.
B) haiku.
C) limerick.
D) sonnet.
E) virelay.

22. The accidental interchange of sounds, usually the initial consonants, in two or more words is called a

A) barbarism.
B) cacozelia.
C) Gongorism.
D) Spoonerism.
E) solecism.

23. The three sisters—for the Greeks, the Moirai, for the Romans, the Parcae—who control birth, life, and death are known as the

A) Brontës.
B) Fates.
C) Graces.
D) Muses.
E) Pleiades.

24. The author of the essay "Hiroshima," which is considered one of the best journalistic articles of the twentieth century, and recipient of the 1945 Pulitzer Prize for Fiction for his *Bell for Adano* is

A) John Hersey.
B) Jhumpha Lahiri.
C) Harper Lee.
D) Sinclair Lewis.
E) Upton Sinclair.

25. A work or manner that blends a censorious attitude with humor and wit for improving human institutions or humanity itself is

A) allegory.
B) diatribe.
C) jeremiad.
D) parody.
E) satire.

26. The nineteenth-century literary movement that rests on the credo "art for art's sake" and whose dominant figures are Oscar Wilde, who insisted on the separation of art and morality, and Walter Pater, is

A) aestheticism.
B) dandyism.
C) Gongorism.
D) objectivism.
E) stoicism.

27. In poetry a pause or break in a line of verse is known as

A) apocope.
B) caesura.
C) elision.
D) hiatus.
E) synalepha.

28. The recipients of the 1946 Pulitzer Prize for Drama for their political and social commentary *State of the Union* are

A) Russel Crouse and Howard Lindsay.
B) Albert Hackett and Frances Goodrich.
C) Moss Hart and George S. Kaufman.
D) James Kirkwood and Nicholas Dante.
E) Stephen Sondheim and James Lapine.

29. **Not** the eighteenth- or nineteenth-century literary period in which historical and religious concerns, ***or*** the romantic spirit, ***or*** pragmatic verisimilitude characterizes the literature is the

A) Colonial Period.
B) Period of Confessional Self.
C) Realistic Period.
D) Revolutionary Period.
E) Romantic Period.

30. The master trope that is characterized by the substitution of the name of an object closely associated with a word for the word itself is

A) eponym.
B) metaphor.
C) metonymy.
D) pseudonym.
E) simile.

**Part 2: The UIL Reading List** **20 items (2 points each)**

**Items 31-37 are associated with William Shakespeare's *A Midsummer Night's Dream*.**
**Items 38-45 are associated with Herman Melville's *Billy Budd, Sailor, An Inside Narrative*.**
**Items 46-50 are associated with Marianne Moore's poetry (selected).**

31. In Shakespeare's *MND* the attempt to place a specific instance against a general background, which is prefaced by the well-known lines "For aught that I could ever read, / Could ever hear by tale or history, / The course of true love never did run smooth," is made by
    A) Egeus.
    B) Lysander.
    C) Oberon.
    D) Philostrate.
    E) Theseus.

32. Theseus includes among "Lovers and madmen [with] such seething brains, / [. . .] that apprehend / More than cool reason ever comprehends," lunatics, lovers, and
    A) Amazons.
    B) fairies.
    C) mechanicals.
    D) poets.
    E) royalty.

33. The incantation "Be as thou wast wont to be. / See as though wast wont to see. / Dian's bud o'er Cupid's flower / Hath such force and blessed power" is uttered by
    A) Oberon to Helena.
    B) Oberon to Hermia.
    C) Oberon to Titania.
    D) Robin to Helena.
    E) Robin to Hermia.

34. Titania's allusion to the lovesick shepherd Corin and the shepherdess Phillida is recognized because they are stock characters of
    A) elegies.
    B) epithalamia.
    C) madrigals.
    D) masques.
    E) pastoral poetry.

35. Demetrius' "It is the wittiest partition that ever I heard discourse" is a snarky compliment regarding
    A) Bottom.
    B) Flute.
    C) Quince.
    D) Snout.
    E) Starveling.

36. Oberon's command to go "About the wood swifter than the wind / And Helena of Athens look thou find / [. . .]" is answered by Robin's "I go, I go, look how I go, / Swifter than arrow from the Tartar's bow," a response built on (a)
    A) condiment.
    B) metaphor.
    C) simile.
    D) synecdoche.
    E) verisimilitude.

37. The warrior Theseus' declaring to his adversary Hippolyta, "I wooed thee with my sword / And won thy love doing thee injuries," constitutes a(n)
    A) antithesis.
    B) hyperbole.
    C) paradox.
    D) tautology.
    E) zeugma.

38. In Melville's *Billy Budd* "the patriarchal irony touching Billy's youth" induces the Dansker to always call Billy
    A) Baby.
    B) Handsome Sailor.
    C) Jemmy Legs.
    D) Squeak.
    E) Starry.

39. Claggart's "conscience being but the lawyer to his will, [makes] ogres of trifles," including finding maliciousness in Billy's
    A) being impressed.
    B) conversing with the Dansker.
    C) inability to talk.
    D) reading the news about the mutinies.
    E) spilling his soup.

40. Billy is informed of the drumhead court's verdict by
    A) Claggart.
    B) Graveling.
    C) Ratcliffe.
    D) Vere.
    E) Wellington.

41. Representing as they do good and evil, respectively, Billy Budd and John Claggart, nevertheless, share

A) admiration for participants in the Nore Mutiny.
B) backgrounds that are obscure.
C) friends back in England.
D) interests in naval history.
E) misgivings about Captain Vere.

42. Constituting "an ariel club lounging at ease against the smaller stun'sails rolled up into cushions, spinning yarns like the lazy gods, and frequently amused with what was going on in the busy world of the decks below" are the

A) afterguardsmen.
B) foretopmen.
C) mizzenmen.
D) powder-boys.
E) tars.

43. Captain Fairfax Vere's nickname, Starry Vere, was given to him by a kinsman who had been reading

A) "Appleton House," an Andrew Marvel poem.
B) the ballad "Billy in the Darbies."
C) Burke's *Reflections on the Revolution in France*.
D) family genealogies.
E) naval navigational charts.

44. Lieutenant Ratcliffe's declaration, "[B]lessed are the peacemakers, especially the fighting peacemakers [. . .] some of which you see poking their noses out of the portholes of yonder warship lying for me," is a reference to the *Bellipotent*'s

A) bluejackets.
B) marine corps.
C) seventy-four cannons.
D) seventy-four crewmembers.
E) three-member drumhead court.

45. "How can we adjudge to summary and shameful death a fellow creature innocent before God, and whom we feel to be so?" is the problem as framed by

A) Master at Arms Claggart.
B) Captain Graveling.
C) Mr. Purser.
D) Lieutenant Ratcliffe.
E) Captain Vere.

**Items 46-47 refer to Marianne Moore's**

**The Mind Is an Enchanting Thing**

is an enchanted thing
    like the glaze on a
katydid-wing
        subdivided by sun
        till the nettings are legion.
Like Gieseking playing Scarlatti;

like the apteryx-awl
    as a beak, or the
kiwi's rain-shawl
        of haired feathers, the mind
        feeling its way as though blind,
walks with its eyes on the ground.

It has memory's ear
    that can hear without
having to hear.
        Like the gyroscope's fall,
        truly unequivocal
because trued by regnant certainty,

it is a power of
    strong enchantment. It
is like the dove-
        neck animated by
        sun; it is memory's eye;
it's conscientious inconsistency.

It tears off the veil; tears
    the temptation, the
mist the heart wears,
        from its eyes—if the heart
        has a face; it takes apart
dejection. It's fire in the dove-neck's

iridescence; in the
    inconsistencies
of Scarlatti.
        Unconfusion submits
        its confusion to proof; it's
not a Herod's oath that cannot change.

46. The imagery found in line 6 and lines 32-33 is

A) auditory.
B) gustatory.
C) olfactory.
D) tactile.
E) visual.

47. The trope that illuminates Moore's fascination with the complexity of the mind's being the object of its own fascination, as exemplified in lines 13-15, is

A) apostrophe.
B) paradox.
C) pun.
D) simile.
E) symbol.

**Items 48-50 refer to Marianne Moore's**

**In This Age of Hard Trying, Nonchalance Is Good And**

"really, it is not the
business of the gods to bake clay pots." They did
not
do it in this instance. A few
revolved upon the axes of their worth
as if excessive popularity might be a pot;

they did not venture the
profession of humility. The polished wedge
that might have split the firmament
was dumb. At last it threw itself away
and falling down, conferred on some poor fool,
a privilege.

"Taller by the length of
a conversation of five hundred years than all
the others," there was one, whose tales
of what could never have been actual
were better than the haggish, uncompanionable
drawl

of certitude; his by
play was more terrible in its effectiveness
than the fiercest frontal attack.
The staff, the bag, the feigned inconse-
quence
of manner, best bespeak that weapon, self-protect-
tiveness.

48. The "feigned inconsequence / of manner" (lines 19-20) of Moore's "In This Age of Hard Trying" echoes the earlier

A) "conversation" (line 12).
B) "excessive popularity" (line 5).
C) "nonchalance" (title).
D) "polished wedge" (line 7).
E) "uncompanionable drawl" (line 15).

49. The second half of the title-phrase, "'really, it is not the / business of the gods to bake clay pots,'" is borrowed from

A) Anton Chekov.
B) Boris Pasternak.
C) Alexander Pushkin.
D) Leo Tolstoy.
E) Ivan Turgenev.

50. The teller of tales—"there was one, whose tales / of what could never have been actual"—is the

A) composer of imaginative fiction.
B) critic.
C) pottery maker.
D) professor.
E) responsive audience.

## Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism
**15 items (2 points each)**

**Items 51-54 refer to Robert Browning's**

**Meeting at Midnight**

I

The grey sea and the long black land;
And the yellow half-moon large and low;
And the startled little waves that leap
In fiery ringlets from their sleep,
As I gain the cove with pushing prow,
And quench its speed i' the slushy sand.

II

Then a mile of warm sea-scented beach;
Three fields to cross till a farm appears;
A tap at the pane, the quick sharp scratch
And blue spurt of a lighted match,
And a voice less loud, thro' its joys and fears,
Than the two hearts beating each to each!

51. Line 6 of Browning's poem is characterized by

A) assonance.
B) jargon.
C) metaphor.
D) onomatopoeia.
E) sigmatism.

52. Lines 3 and 4 offer an example of

A) allegory.
B) irony.
C) metonymy.
D) personification.
E) reification.

53. The end rhyme of lines 2 and 5 constitute an example of

A) compound rhyme.
B) eye rhyme.
C) feminine rhyme.
D) leonine rhyme.
E) triple rhyme.

54. The focus of stanza one and the focus of stanza two suggest different

A) colors.
B) modes of travel.
C) sounds.
D) times of day.
E) varieties of soils.

**Items 55-58 refer to E. E. Cummings's**

**since feeling is first**

since feeling is first
who pays any attention
to the syntax of things
will never wholly kiss you;
wholly to be a fool
while Spring is in the world

my blood approves,
and kisses are a better fate
than wisdom
lady i swear by all flowers. Don't cry
—the best gesture of my brain is less than
your eyelids' flutter which says

we are for each other: then
laugh, leaning back in my arms
for life's not a paragraph

And death i think is no parenthesis

55. The controlling image of Cummings's "since feeling is first" is the conceit involving *syntax* (line 3), which is continued in lines

A) 6 and 7.
B) 7 and 8.
C) 8 and 9.
D) 11 and 12.
E) 15 and 16.

56. Death as an interruption (line 16) is understood in terms of

A) allusion.
B) fatalism.
C) litotes.
D) semiotics.
E) syntax.

57. The comparison found in lines 11-12 argues the supremacy of

A) brains over eyelashes.
B) emotion over reason.
C) flowers over crying.
D) gestures over flutters.
E) wisdom over blood.

58. The use of *Spring* in the declaration "wholly to be a fool / while Spring is in the world / my blood approves" is

A) didactic.
B) hyperbolic.
C) metaphorical.
D) oxymoronic.
E) vatic.

**Items 59-60 refer to Mary Holtby's**

**Milk-cart**

Slow sleet, still street; far beat huge feet;
Clip-clop, start-stop, ear-flop, turd-drop;
Pint-take, gate-shake, sleep-break, house-wake;
Short-stay; stamp, neigh; on way—new day.

59. The rhyme that dominates Holtby's poem is

A) beginning rhyme.
B) compound rhyme.
C) feminine rhyme.
D) identical rhyme.
E) leonine rhyme.

60. An interesting aspect of Holtby's "Milk-cart" is the onomatopoeic use of

A) dactyls.
B) iambs.
C) pyrrhics.
D) spondees.
E) trochees.

**Items 61-65 refer to James Russell Lowell's**

**Auspex** *

My heart, I cannot still it,
Nest that had song-birds in it;
And when the last shall go,
The dreary days to fill it,
Instead of lark or linnet,
Shall whirl dead leaves and snow.

Had they been swallows only,
Without the passion stronger
That skyward longs and sings,—
Woe's me, I shall be lonely
When I can feel no longer
The impatience of their wings!

A moment, sweet delusion,
Like birds the brown leaves hover;
But it will not be long
Before their wild confusion
Fall wavering down to cover
The poet and his song.

*** Roman auger who watched for omens in the flight of birds**

61. The rhyme scheme of Lowell's "Auspex" is

A) *aabaab*.
B) *ababab*.
C) *abbabb*.
D) *abcabc*.
E) *accacc*.

62. Overwhelming, the poem's rhyme features

A) alliteration.
B) dissonance.
C) feminine endings.
D) onomatopoeia.
E) syncopation.

63. The phrase "sweet delusion" (line 13) is

A) hyperbolic.
B) metaphorical.
C) onomatopoeic.
D) oxymoronic.
E) paradoxical.

64. From the poet's heart—his nest—has flown the songbirds—his happiness, the happiness that is the source of his

A) impatience.
B) interest in birds.
C) knowledge of augury.
D) poetic inspiration.
E) woe.

65. The tone of lines 13-14 is

A) ecstatic.
B) fatalistic.
C) irreverent.
D) ominous.
E) pessimistic.

**Tie-breaking essay prompt on the next page.**

**Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay (required)**

**Note well: Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified even if they are not involved in any tie.**

**Note well: Any essay that does not demonstrate a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic will be disqualified. The judge(s) should note carefully this criterion when breaking ties: ranking of essays for tie-breaking purposes should be based primarily on how well the topic has been addressed.**

Three sheets of paper have been provided for this essay; your written response should reflect the *Handbook*'s notion that an essay is a "moderately brief discussion of a restricted topic": something more than just a few sentences.

---

Read William Wordsworth's "To Sleep," and discuss the persona's attitude regarding Sleep, focusing especially on the names that he uses to describe Sleep.

**To Sleep**

Fond words have oft been spoken to thee, Sleep!
And thou hast had thy store of tenderest names;
The very sweetest, Fancy* culls or frames, — **Imagination**
When thankfulness of heart is strong and deep!
Dear Bosom-child we call thee, that dost steep* — **soak, drown**
In rich reward all suffering; Balm* that tames — **soothing ointment**
All anguish; Saint that evil thoughts and aims
Takest away, and into souls dost creep,
Like to a breeze from heaven. Shall I alone,
I surely not a man ungently made,
Call thee worst Tyrant by which Flesh is crost? * — **crossed**
Perverse, self-willed to own and to disown,
Mere slave of them who never for thee prayed,
Still last to come where thou art wanted most!

# University Interscholastic League
# Literary Criticism Contest
# District 2 • 2012
# KEY

Page numbers are those associated with the *Handbook* 11e, the Penguin 1986 edition of *Budd*, and the Folger edition of *MND*.

**Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History** **30 items (1 point each)**

| | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1. | E | 406 | 11. | C | 643-49 | 21. | C | 314 |
| 2. | A | 16 | 12. | D | 169 | 22. | D | 523 |
| 3. | A | 230 | 13. | B | | 23. | B | 225 |
| 4. | C | 661 | 14. | C | 391 | 24. | A | 660 |
| 5. | B | 90 | 15. | D | 285 | 25. | E | 490 |
| 6. | E | 565 | 16. | C | 630 | 26. | A | 7 |
| 7. | B | 657 | 17. | E | 550 | 27. | B | 81 |
| 8. | E | 577 | 18. | A | 28 | 28. | A | 664 |
| 9. | D | 663 | 19. | A | 9 | 29. | B | 21 |
| 10. | D | 241 | 20. | A | 152 | 30. | C | 344 |

---

**Part 2: UIL Reading List** **20 items ( 2 points each)**

| | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 31. | B | 1.1.134-36 | 38. | A | 320 | 45. | E | 361 |
| 32. | D | 5.1.4-8 | 39. | E | 330 | 46. | A | |
| 33. | C | 4.1.72-76 | 40. | D | 366 | 47. | B | 398 |
| 34. | E | 2.1.68-70 | 41. | B | | 48. | C | |
| 35. | D | 5.1.176-77 | 42. | B | 317 | 49. | E | |
| 36. | C | 3.2.96-103 | 43. | A | 310 | 50. | A | |
| 37. | C | 1.1.17-18 | 44. | C | 296 | | | |

---

**Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism** **15 items ( 2 points each)**

| | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 51. | E | 513 | 56. | E | 543, line 3 | 61. | D | |
| 52. | D | 412 | 57. | B | | 62. | C | 226 |
| 53. | B | 220 | 58. | C | 340 | 63. | D | 392 |
| 54. | B | | 59. | E | 312 | 64. | D | |
| 55. | E | | 60. | D | 522 | 65. | A | |

**Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay**

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

---

**Critical Notes on William Wordsworth's "To Sleep"**

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of these poems include

allusion,
ambivalence (not ambiguity),
apostrophe,
litotes,
muse,
octave,
personification,
rhyme,
sigmatism,
simile,
sonnet (Italian),
synecdoche,
turn (volta), and
tone.

Recognizing that the persona addresses Sleep in both positive terms and negative terms, the young writer might focus simply on the ambivalence that the range of terms suggests.

That the persona admits that he alone might be the only person unhappy with Sleep (line 11) should be noted; however, if the young writer doesn't perceive that the problem might be insomnia (Sleep is "last to come where [it is] wanted most!"), it should not be seen as a failing in an otherwise solid discussion of the complimentary descriptors and, on the other hand, the disparaging, perhaps deprecating, descriptors.

In addition to noting both the ambivalence and the possibility that insomnia might be the subject of the poem, the perceptive competitor might recognize the sonnet's sestet as something of a prayer (the sonnet is an apostrophe)—troubling and mildly desperate in tone.

The well-read Lit Critter might recognize an echo of Macbeth's praise of sleep in the "fond words" found in lines 6-7: "Balm that tames / All anguish." Indeed, he or she might perceive the sonnet's octave as a catalogue of praise by poets past and the octave as a rebuttal of a history of praise in an attempt to induce Sleep to come to the persona's aid.